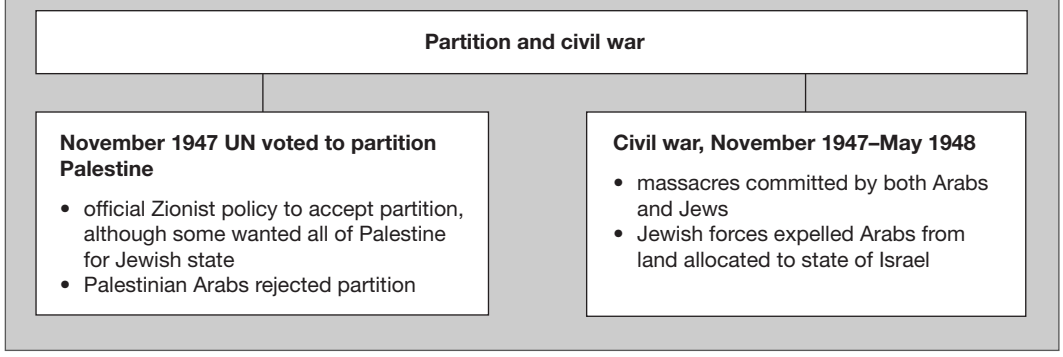
Summary diagram: Partition and civil war 1947–8



3 | The War of 1948–9

Key dates

Declaration of new state of Israel: 14 May 1948

Invasion of Israel by Arab armies: 15 May 1948

On the 14 May 1948 David Ben-Gurion proclaimed the birth of the new state of Israel. The next day armed forces from Lebanon, Syria, Iraq, Transjordan and Egypt invaded. The state of Israel was thus born in war and its first aim was survival. Israel's War of Independence was to consist of three phases of fighting, interspersed by UN ceasefires.

The first phase of fighting, 15 May to 10 June 1948

In the south an Egyptian army of 10,000 men crossed the border near the coast and attacked some isolated Jewish settlements in what was to be the Arab state. In the north, Syrian, Iraqi and Lebanese troops crossed the border but were resisted by Jewish settlers and most of the invaders were forced to withdraw. They lacked ammunition and were the least experienced of the Arab forces.

Key question
Why was the struggle for Jerusalem so important for the Israelis?

The major conflict was the battle for Jerusalem, just as it had been in the final days of the British mandate. King Abdullah of Transjordan moved his **Arab Legion** to defend the Old City, the eastern part, of Jerusalem. His army was the one that the Israelis were keenest to defeat, for two main reasons. First, they wanted to gain control of all of the city of Jerusalem, including the Old City which contained the Jewish holy places. Secondly, they knew that the Legion was the most effective and best-trained Arab army and they believed that, if they could defeat it, then the other Arab armies would collapse. However, the Israelis were not able to defeat the Legion and the Israeli offensive was halted. Nevertheless, the Israelis did gain control of west Jerusalem without a big struggle and were thus able to feed and protect the Jewish population in that part of the city.

Key term

Arab Legion
The army of Transjordan.

Ceasefire, June 1948

On 10 June the UN persuaded the warring parties to agree to a ceasefire. The Jordanians and Lebanese were willing to open peace talks but the Egyptians, Syrians and Iraqis were not. During